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THE WORLD'S LARGEST VACCINATION DRIVE

1 JANUARY 2021

INDIA | 2,51,255 ACTIVE CASES | 1,39,084 DEATHS

WORLD | 1,60,77,452 ACTIVE CASES | 19,45,918 DEATHS

The special expert committee of the CDSCO convened to discuss the proposals submitted by Bharat Biotech and SSI for their respective vaccine candidates: Covaxin and Covishield. No proposal from Pfizer had come through and they remained absent from the meeting as well. For a vaccine to be given approval, three types of data sets need to be looked at: safety data, immunogenicity data and efficacy data. Safety data analyses mild and adverse effects of the vaccines on a large number of people. Immunogenicity is the antibody response generated in individuals as a result of the administered vaccines. To comprehend efficacy data, we need to first understand how it is calculated. As part of the trial, the vaccine is administered to a large number of people, after which the number of infected people among the vaccinated group versus the number of infected from the placebo group are compared after a certain number of infections occur; which then tells us how efficacious the vaccine is. This is a time-consuming process, because a minimum number of events need to occur, i.e., people need to be infected, the study needs to be unwinded, and vaccinated and placebo groups need to be compared. There is no way to predict how much time it may take for those predecided number of events to take place.

In the case of SII, the firm had adequate safety, immunogenicity as well as efficacy data from their UK study which enrolled over 20,000